SIKKIM

A Chance for Chamling

By Romita Datta



SUBIR HALDER

MAN FOR ALL SEASONS Former CM of Sikkim Pawan Kumar Chamling is playing hard for a comeback in 2024

Anti-incumbency is an unpredictable phenomenon—it can afflict governments when they are least expecting it. Three years after the Sikkim Krantikari Morcha (SKM)-led government came to power—itself riding on the back of anti-incumbency against former chief minister Pawan Kumar Chamling's 25-year government—it's already beset by a lack of public confidence in it. In 2019, the tedium of status quo and the SKM's slogan of *parivartan* enthused the youth and gave it a narrow victory in the assembly polls. The SKM was only six years old, but its leader P.S. Golay, an old aide of Chamling, appeared a viable alternative. Besides, their manifesto was bountiful: jobs or monthly allowances for the unemployed, support prices for ginger, orange, cardamom crops, allowances for women and so forth.

In the assembly polls, the SKM won 17 seats, while Chamling's Sikkim Democratic Front (SDM) won 15 seats in a 32-seat assembly. Significantly, the SDF won a larger vote share (47.63 per cent) than the SKM (47.17 per cent). However, it soon found itself in dire straits. Ten out of its 15 MLAs joined the BJP and two joined the ruling SKM after the polls. After two MLAs had to vacate one of the two seats they had won, the SDF's assembly strength fell to a lone MLA—Chamling himself, India's longest-serving CM till then.

However, much of the enthusiasm around the SKM has fizzled out within three years. "The party made unrealistic promises. For example, creation of 30,000 jobs for youths, a monthly unemployment allowance of Rs 10,000, a yearly allowance of Rs 1,00,000 for family matriarchs for five years...," says Barap Namgyal, head of SDF's social media cell. Yet, unemployment figures grew under the SKM's watch and more people were pushed into poverty. Especially hard-hit was the rural economy.

"Farmers' pension of Rs 1,000 a month, widow pension and festival allowance have been stopped. The promise of regularising part-time jobs for 20,000 young people within 100 days of the new government has not been fulfilled. We had brought in this government with a lot of hope but now we see ourselves being fooled," says a resident from Namchi, south Sikkim. The deeply felt disaffection cuts across age, gender and socio-economic class.

"The government came to power making time-bound promises. Naturally, people are restless when they remain unfulfilled. The government's credibility has taken a beating. Youths are disillusioned the most," says SDF vice-president P.D. Rai. The time, in